Continuous fluorouracil + radiotherapy

NCCP 00421 · Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending

YOUR TREATMENT, STEP BY STEP

Your port and treatment pump

From preparing the line to coming home after disconnection. Your team arranges the appointments and shows you what to do.

1 · Before treatment

Choose and prepare the line

The team explains whether a port or PICC suits your treatment. You receive instructions for the insertion appointment.

2 · Insertion and recovery

A separate appointment may be needed

For a port, numbing medicine is used and a small device is placed under the skin. Ask about sedation, transport and wound care.

3 · Day 1

The nurse connects your pump

After the day-ward medicines, the nurse checks and connects the fluorouracil pump. Ask for a demonstration before leaving.

4 · At home

Continuous infusion throughout the week

Fluorouracil runs continuously, seven days a week, during the six-week radiotherapy course. Keep the pump and dressing protected as taught.

5 · Every seven days

Professional pump change

The team changes the pump weekly and checks the line. Attend the separate radiotherapy schedule. Do not disconnect or change the pump yourself.

6 · Throughout the course

Ongoing line care

The access device stays in place as planned. Keep the written line-care and urgent-contact instructions; the team confirms completion and disconnection.

Port or PICC: what is the difference?

A port is a small chamber beneath the skin, usually on the chest, attached to a tube ending in a large vein. A special needle goes through the skin into the port when it is used. A PICC enters a vein in the upper arm; a short section remains outside under a dressing. Both can deliver a home infusion. Your team helps choose the device and teaches its care.

Before insertion and during recovery

Tell the team about allergies, blood thinners, infections and any other cancer medicines. Follow the instructions about eating, drinking and transport; do not stop medicines yourself. Port placement uses local anaesthetic, sometimes with sedation or general anaesthetic. The team explains the procedure and risks, including infection, bleeding, clots and insertion complications. Ask how to manage discomfort, protect the wound and resume activity. Report increasing pain, redness, swelling, discharge or fever.

Connection: what the nurse does

The nurse checks the line and treatment, secures the connection and dressing, and starts the pump. Before leaving, you should have the disconnection location and time, contact numbers including out of hours, and the written spill instructions. Ask to be shown what normal pump progress looks like. You do not need to calculate a rate.

Carrying it, sleeping and washing

Use the supplied carrier and the position recommended for your pump. Keep tubing free from pulling and kinks. Ask how to place the pump safely for sleep and how to protect the line and dressing when washing. Do not immerse it or swim. Avoid direct heat and cold. An elastomeric pump has a balloon that shrinks slowly and may have no alarm; an electronic pump has different instructions. Follow the instructions for the device you actually receive.

Disconnection is not port removal

Keep the appointment even if the pump looks empty, unless the team changes the plan. Staff check the pump and line and arrange safe disposal. After flushing and other line care as required, the port needle may be removed and a small dressing applied. The implanted port stays in place until a separate removal procedure is arranged. A PICC remains in place and needs scheduled dressing and flushing care.

Leakage, disconnection or unexpected pump progress

Call the team immediately if the pump leaks, is damaged, finishes unexpectedly early, appears not to run, or the line disconnects. Follow the emergency or spill steps you have been specifically taught, including use of a clamp if instructed. Do not reconnect, change settings or disconnect the pump yourself. Keep other people away from leaked medicine. If medicine touches skin, rinse it off and wash with soap and water, then seek advice.

Pain, swelling or feeling unwell

Contact oncology immediately for pain or swelling around the line, a wet/loose dressing, redness, fever, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell. A painful swollen arm or neck needs urgent advice. Severe chest pain, major breathing difficulty or collapse: call 112 / 999. Do not wait for pump disconnection or the next clinic visit.

The drawings show general steps, not instructions for inserting or accessing a line. Your hospital confirms its own arrangements and the care instructions for your device.

Sources: eviQ: port · eviQ: PICC · eviQ: pump. Reviewed against these sources 16 October 2026; local nursing and patient review pending.